brother Jan, who was on vacation from university in Potchefstroom. I explained to Jan what had happened, and he walked over to Allan and said: 'If you ever touch my little brother again, you will regret it.'

That was that.

We were never again bothered by Allan and his friends.

There was time for some formal education as well.

Warmbaths Primary School provided me, and many others, with an ideal start in life. There were many excellent teachers with strong values, a clear structure and proper discipline, all wrapped in the kindness and warmth typical of a small town where almost everyone knew almost everyone else.

The spirit of the school was most accurately reflected in the concept of the 'school patrol' where Standard 4 boys were designated to stand at the zebra crossing on the adjacent road at the start of each day and ensure their fellow pupils crossed safely. I was one of the boys given this responsibility in 1996 and, although it meant getting up early and being in position from 6.30 until 7.15 am every morning for a year, even in the freezing depths of winter, the school patrol taught me the importance of being organised and being on time.

Beyond my brothers, my friends and my school, the most significant influence on these formative years was, of course, my parents ... my endlessly giving and unconditionally loving parents.

AB and Millie married at a relatively young age and moved around what was then the Transvaal, eventually settling when AB took a position as a doctor in a general practice in Warmbaths.

My father has always been busy. Doctors always have patients who need to be seen and, when I was young, this commitment meant that, most of the time, he was unable to attend my matches. It followed that the days when he was standing on the touchline with the other parents, the rare occasions when he could get away from the practice, became